Little Women

A simplified retelling

Original story by Louisa May Alcott

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

1. Four sisters

The March sisters were not looking forward to Christmas. Their father was away serving as a chaplain during the American Civil War, and the family had little money.

Meg, the eldest, remembered when life had been easier. Jo wanted to write stories and disliked being told how a young lady should behave. Beth was shy and loved music. Amy, the youngest, wanted to become an artist and cared greatly about looking refined.

Their mother, whom they called Marmee, encouraged them to think beyond what they lacked. On Christmas morning, they took their breakfast to a family who had even less. Later, their wealthy neighbour, Mr Laurence, sent them a feast in appreciation.

Jo became friendly with his grandson, Laurie. He lived in a grand house but often felt lonely. The lively March household offered something his own home could not provide. Soon he was included in their games, performances and everyday adventures.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

2. Lessons at home

The sisters loved one another, but living together was not always peaceful. When Jo refused to take Amy out with her, Amy burned the manuscript Jo had been writing. Jo was furious and would barely speak to her.

Later, Amy followed Jo and Laurie onto a frozen river. The ice broke beneath her. Laurie helped pull her out, and Jo realised how close she had come to losing her sister while refusing to forgive her.

Marmee did not pretend that anger vanished simply because one understood it. She told Jo that managing it required practice.

Meg sometimes envied richer girls and enjoyed borrowing fine clothes. Beth found a generous friend in Mr Laurence, who gave her a piano. Amy tried to improve her manners. Each sister had a different struggle, and none could complete another’s growing up for her.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

3. Illness and a homecoming

When their father became ill, Marmee travelled to care for him. Jo cut and sold her hair to help pay for the journey. She tried to laugh about it, but cried privately over what she had given up.

While Marmee was away, Beth visited the poor family they had helped at Christmas. She caught scarlet fever and became dangerously ill. Amy was sent to stay elsewhere to avoid infection. Jo remained close to Beth and feared she might die.

Marmee returned, and Beth slowly recovered, though her health was never fully restored.

Their father came home too. The family was together again, but the girls were beginning to understand that love did not protect a household from every frightening thing.

Meg had grown close to Laurie’s tutor, John Brooke. Aunt March objected because he was not wealthy. Meg chose him for his character, and they eventually married in a simple ceremony at home.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

4. New responsibilities

Meg’s married life brought happiness and difficulties. Money was limited. After buying expensive fabric she could not really afford, she had to face the difference between wanting a beautiful life and paying for one. She and John learned to talk more honestly.

Jo sold stories and enjoyed earning money. She hoped to support her family through writing. Laurie had grown to love her, but Jo did not feel the same way.

When he proposed, she refused. She loved him as a friend and knew that accepting him out of pity would be unfair. He was deeply hurt and went abroad with his grandfather.

Amy also travelled in Europe, where she studied art. She enjoyed beautiful places, but began to recognise the difference between liking the life of an artist and possessing exceptional artistic ability. She considered what kind of useful, generous life she could build with the talents she actually had.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

5. Jo in New York

Jo went to New York to work as a governess and to write. There she met Professor Friedrich Bhaer, a kind German teacher with little money. He was thoughtful and unpretentious.

Jo was earning money through sensational stories. A conversation about such writing made her uncomfortable. Bhaer did not know that she wrote it, but his concerns encouraged her to question what she wanted her work to offer readers.

Away from home, she found more room to think. Yet Beth’s health was declining, and Jo returned to be with her.

They went to the seaside. At first, Jo tried to imagine a happy future in which Beth would recover. Beth gently helped her understand that she knew she was dying.

There was no grand adventure Jo could undertake to fix this. She could stay, listen and make the remaining time as loving as possible.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

6. Love and loss

Beth died at home, surrounded by the care of her family. The quiet sister left a space that could not be filled simply by being busy.

Jo began writing from feelings she knew intimately. Stories about ordinary family life reached readers in a way that some of her more dramatic work had not.

In Europe, Amy and Laurie met again. She challenged his habit of wasting time and feeling sorry for himself. He discovered that she had become thoughtful and capable. Their affection grew gradually, and they married before returning home.

Jo was happy for them. Her earlier refusal had not destroyed their friendship; it had allowed them to find different futures.

Bhaer came to visit the March family. Jo waited anxiously for signs of his feelings. Finally, during a walk in the rain, they spoke honestly and became engaged. Their plans were modest, but they shared the desire to make a useful home.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

7. A school and a gathering

When Aunt March died, she left Jo her large house, Plumfield. Jo and Bhaer turned it into a school for boys, combining learning with affection and practical activity.

Meg raised her children with John. Amy and Laurie used their comfort to help others. Jo discovered that building a school did not mean abandoning her imagination. It gave her another way to use it.

At a family gathering, the sisters and their mother looked at the lives around them. Their childhood dreams had not all come true in their original forms. There had been disappointment, work and grief alongside happiness.

Beth was absent, but she remained part of how they cared for one another.

The girls who had once complained about Christmas presents had become women with homes, responsibilities and unfinished hopes. They had not learned a single secret that made life easy. They had learned, repeatedly, how to begin again together.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

Words to keep

Manuscript — a written work before publication. Amy burned Jo’s manuscript.

Refined — showing polished manners or taste. Amy wanted to appear refined.

Sacrifice — giving up something valuable to help someone. Jo’s haircut was a sacrifice.

Envy — wishing you had what someone else has. Meg sometimes felt envy around wealthy friends.

Sensational — designed to excite or shock. Jo earned money from sensational stories.

Grief — deep sadness after a loss. The family shared grief after Beth’s death.

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.

A question to carry with you

Which sister’s difficulty feels most familiar to you? What does she learn that might help someone in your life?

© 2026 Founded by Mira Nasser Louis.